

ON A WINNING NOTE
The Nagaland Chamber Choir at Gangneung, South Korea

On an overcast July afternoon, a big crowd of local politicians, civil society figures and media personnel had gathered outside the airport terminal at Dimapur in Nagaland, holding flags and welcome banners. Cheers went up as they sighted their quarry: a group of 30-odd people from all walks of life, who sing together as The Nagaland Chamber Choir (TNCC). The group had just made history in Gangneung, South Korea, where they won two gold medals at the prestigious 12th World Choir Games. This was their welcoming committee.

After a round of hugs and an exchange of bouquets, the choir formed up for a stirring impromptu performance of the Don Besig and Nancy Price classic 'As Long As I Have Music'. Heavenly harmonies filled the air outside the airport terminal. "We are determined to sing as long as we have music," Dr Limawati Pongen, TNCC's co-ordinator, told the assembled crowd in an emotional speech. "That is our commitment, and we will see what comes our way next."

Choral music has a long history in Nagaland, dating back to the late 19th century when American Baptist missionaries first brought Christianity to the region. Every church in the state has its own choir, as do most schools. Kids grow up learning the classic Latin and English hymns—as well as indigenously written tunes inspired by folk music traditions—and choirs grace most major community occasions, from festivals to weddings.

But, towards the latter half of the last century, this tradition began to lose ground to the increasing popularity of secular music (pop, rock, even Indian film music). TNCC—founded in 2003 by Kughaho Chishi—was set up to reverse this trend. "It was started to promote indigenous and choral music in Nagaland," says Dr Pongen, speaking over the phone from Dimapur. "With choral music being the main ingredient in the ministry of the churches, our aim was to equip and support people in the music ministry."

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For the past 20 years, TNCC has performed all over the Northeast and the rest of the country, even travelling abroad to sing at events like the centenary of the World Baptist Alliance in Birmingham, UK. The group's first big international win came in 2017, when they took part in the 4th Asia-Pacific Choir Games in Colombo. The choir won two silver medals as well as two gold diplomas at the event, paving the way for qualification to this year's World Choir Games.

"It was such a joy for us," says Dr Pongen, pointing out that TNCC was the first Indian choir to be invited to the biennial competition organised by global NGO Interkultur. "At the same time, we felt incredible responsibility as the only choir group representing our country."

"I had mixed feelings, because I didn't think we were ready for such a big stage," adds the choir's